

Stylistic applicatives: a lens into the nature of anticausative *SE**

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Abstract

This paper examines an understudied syntactic phenomenon in Chilean Spanish: *stylistic applicatives*. This construction involves the appearance of the form *LE* alongside dative clitics in marked anticausative contexts. The pattern displays several puzzling properties, the most striking being that the anticausative/reflexive marker *SE* becomes optional in it, i.e., its presence or absence does not affect the interpretation of the sentence. I argue that this optionality arises from two interconnected factors. First, stylistic applicatives involve multiple exponence of an applicative head, realized as two separate clitic forms. Second, one of the resulting exponents, which is formally similar to a reflexive clitic, is able to replace *SE* in the surface representation of the sentence. This analysis supports the view that anticausative *SE* is a semantically vacuous marker whose role is purely formal: to signal the absence of an external argument in anticausative constructions.

Keywords— Anticausative markers; clitic clusters; microvariation; stylistic applicatives; Chilean Spanish

1 Introduction

Spanish expresses the causative alternation through two distinct mechanisms. On one hand, it features unmarked anticausative verbs, i.e., verbs that require no morphological marking to function as anticausatives. These are verbs such as *hervir* ‘boil’, *mejorar* ‘improve’ and *disminuir* ‘diminish’. The number of lexical items belonging to this class is very limited.

- (1) a. Cosmo hirvió el agua.
Cosmo boiled.3SG the water
‘Cosmo boiled the water.’
b. El agua hirvió.
the water boiled.3SG
‘The water boiled.’

In the vast majority of cases, however, Spanish employs a marking strategy to signal the anticausative form of the verb. This is attested in the pair of sentences in (2), where the clitic form *SE* combines with the verb *abrió* ‘opened’ to form an anticausative predicate. This mechanism serves as the primary means by which anticausative constructions are generated in the language.¹

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¹For a comprehensive discussion of the causative alternation in Spanish, see Vivanco (2016).

- (2) a. Cosmo abrió la puerta.
 Cosmo opened.3SG the door
 ‘Cosmo opened the door.’
 b. La puerta se abrió.
 the door SE opened.3SG
 ‘The door opened.’

The form *SE* appearing in (2b) belongs to the class of reflexive elements in Spanish, and serves various roles related to voice alternations (e.g., Mendikoetxea 1999, 2012, Trebisacce 2020, Fábregas 2021). Similar scenarios are attested throughout the Romance family (e.g., DobrovieSorin 2017, Martin 2023). The examples in (3) illustrate the paradigm of Spanish reflexive clitics. As can be seen, *SE* functions as a third person reflexive pronoun in the language, allowing to indicate that one of the objects of the verb must be interpreted as being coreferential with the grammatical subject.²

- (3) a. Yo me peino.
 1SG.NOM REFL.1SG comb.1SG
 ‘I comb myself’
 b. Tú te peinas.
 2SG.NOM REFL.2SG comb.2SG
 ‘You comb yourself’
 c. Él se peina.
 3SG.NOM REFL.3 comb.3SG
 ‘He combs himself’
 d. Nosotros nos peinamos.
 1PL.NOM REFL.1PL comb.1PL
 ‘We comb ourselves.’
 e. Ellos se peinan.
 3PL.NOM REFL.3 comb.3PL
 ‘They comb themselves.’

In principle, the functional multiplicity of *SE* suggests two distinct ways of understanding its role in Spanish anticausative predicates. The first one involves the hypothesis that reflexive and anticausative constructions have some sort of similarity at the semantic level, and that *SE* contributes the same meaning in both cases. Thus, if *SE* introduces a coreferential interpretation between two arguments of the verb in reflexive sentences such as (3c) and (3e), it must be doing something very similar for the anticausative predicate in (2b). Authors like Chierchia (2004) and Koontz-Garboden (2009) hold this point of view.

Conversely, the observation that *SE* surfaces in constructions that are apparently unrelated otherwise might lead to the hypothesis that it contributes no meaning at all (at least for one of them), and that it rather serves a purely formal function. Thus, for instance, its role in anticausative predicates might be that of filling a structural slot left available by the absence of an agentive nominal phrase. This line of hypothesis has been advanced in different ways by Schäfer (2008), Pujalte & Saab (2012), Alexiadou et al. (2015) and Saab (2020), among others.

In this paper, I introduce a novel data set from Chilean Spanish that supports the claim that *SE* contributes no meaning at all to anticausative predicates. The evidence comes from the behavior of *stylistic applicatives*, an understudied syntactic phenomenon in which a dative-like form surfaces next to a dative clitic in certain contexts. In these scenarios, anticausative *SE* becomes optional, in the sense that its presence or absence does not alter the interpretation of the sentence. Crucially, the optionality of *SE* in this construction seems to rely on the availability of extra elements in the surface representation of the sentence that are formally similar to it and can, therefore, fulfill its role in anticausative constructions.

The structure of the paper is as follows. Section 2 presents the phenomenon of stylistic applicatives as attested in Chilean Spanish. Section 3 discusses two puzzling properties of the construction: first, it exhibits restrictions on clitic clusters that do not appear to follow from previously known constraints;

²The paradigm in (3) omits 2PL forms, which are fully syncretic with 3PL in American Spanish; see, for instance, Harris (1998).

second, it requires no *SE*-marking to trigger anticausative interpretations, seemingly showing that this element has no active role in determining the meaning of the construction. Section 4 offers an analysis for the phenomenon: it maintains that the pattern results from a single applicative head being pronounced as two separate clitic forms; since one of them is superficially undistinguishable from a reflexive element, it can replace anticausative *SE*, rendering this element optional. Section 5 expands the proposal to include cases where stylistic applicatives appear in predicates that are not anticausative. Finally, section 6 contains the conclusions.

2 The basic pattern

Spanish allows to add a non-core dative argument to a predicate (Cuervo 2003, Pujalte 2012, Suárez-Palma 2020). The relevant phenomenon is exemplified in (4), where a 1SG dative clitic is added to the verb *abrió* ‘opened’ to turn it into a ditransitive predicate. For most of the cases that will be relevant here, the clitic is interpreted as referring to an entity affected by a change of state of a theme object. Thus, for instance, the pronoun *me* in (4b) refers to an entity, the speaker, that is affected by the door becoming open.

- (4) a. Cosmo abrió la puerta.
Cosmo opened.3SG the door
‘Cosmo opened the door.’
b. Cosmo me abrió la puerta.
Cosmo 1SG.DAT opened.3SG the door
‘Cosmo opened the door for/on/to me.’

Affected datives like *me* in (4b) can co-appear with marked anticausative predicates, e.g., (5). In these cases, the anticausative marker *SE* and the dative clitic conform a clitic cluster of the form *SE+CL_{dat}*, e.g., *se me* in (5).

- (5) Se me abrió la puerta.
SE 1SG.DAT opened.3SG the door
‘The door opened for/on/to me.’
‘I unintentionally opened the door.’

As the glosses indicate, the dative argument in this construction may also be interpreted as an unintentional causer of the change-of-state event denoted by the anticausative predicate. This sort of interpretation is systematic for sentences combining affected datives and anticausatives, and is attested in a variety of languages (Kallulli 2006, Schäfer 2008, Alexiadou et al. 2015).

- (6) Joannie zbił się kubek.
Joanna.DAT broke REFL mug.NOM
‘Joanna unintentionally broke the mug.’ *Polish*
- (7) Benit i-u thye dritarja.
Ben.DAT DAT.CL3S-NACT broke.AOR.3S window.NOM
‘Ben unintentionally broke the window.’ *Albanian (Kallulli 2006: 274)*
- (8) Dem Peter zerbrach versehentlich die Vase.
the.DAT John broke accidentally the.NOM vase
‘Peter accidentally broke the vase.’ *German (Schäfer 2008: 81)*
- (9) A Francesca si ruppe il vaso.
to.DAT Francesca REFL broke the.NOM vase
‘Francesca unintentionally caused the vase to break.’ *Italian (Alexiadou et al. 2015: 45)*

The Spanish variety spoken in Central Chile also displays the pattern in (5), but it further has the option to convey the same meaning in two other ways. The first variant is through a sequence of clitics of the form $CL_{dat}+LE$, that seemingly replaces the anticausative marker SE for the form LE , which is traditionally the exponent corresponding to a 3SG dative clitic pronoun in the language, e.g., (10a). The second option involves a cluster of the form $SE+CL_{dat}+LE$, in which anticausative SE and LE appear together, e.g., (10b). In both cases, the dative clitic CL_{dat} is a pronoun referring to the affected entity, while LE is an invariable element that exhibits no referential property.

- (10) a. Me le abrió la puerta.
 1SG.DAT LE opened.3SG the door
 ‘The door opened for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally opened the door.’
 b. Se me le abrió la puerta.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE opened.3SG the door

There are very few mentions of this phenomenon in the linguistic literature. It was first reported by Kany (1945: 139), and it was later alluded to by Oroz (1966: 174) and Campos (1999: 1571); Silva-Corvalán (2005) discusses the pattern from a sociopragmatic point of view. Kany introduces it as “indefinite redundant LE ”. This denomination assimilates the patterns in (10) to what he calls “redundant LE ”, i.e., instances of dative clitic doubling. Given that LE in examples like those in (10) does not seem to be “redundant” (i.e., correferential) with any other element in the sentence, and considering that it introduces no new meaning when compared to the base example in (5), I will refer to it simply as *stylistic LE*.

Stylistic LE is a non-standard grammatical phenomenon in Chilean Spanish. Its usage is stigmatized from a prescriptive point of view as it is traditionally associated with low levels of education. For instance, Oroz characterizes it as being “more common in working-class environments than among well-educated individuals” (1966: 376). The study by Silva-Corvalán (2005) seems to confirm this sociolinguistic distribution, as it identifies the relevant patterns in the speech of adult individuals who have not completed elementary school. However, in recent years, the construction has seemingly extended to the informal speech of young speakers of Central Chile, irrespective of their educational background; a thorough study is necessary to corroborate this informal observation.

As mentioned, patterns like (10) may arise in contexts combining SE -marked anticausatives and affected datives. Thus, all verbs that participate in the causative alternation in (2), e.g., *romper* ‘break’, *hundir* ‘sink’, are able to host them. As shown in (11) and (12), these verbs not only employ the standard $SE+CL_{dat}$ clitic cluster combination, e.g., (11a) and (12a), but also may exhibit the patterns involving stylistic LE , i.e., $CL_{dat}+LE$, e.g., (11b) and (12b), and $SE+CL_{dat}+LE$, e.g., (11c) and (12c).

- (11) a. Se me rompió la radio.
 SE 1SG.DAT broke.3SG the radio
 ‘The radio broke for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally broke the radio.’
 b. Me le rompió la radio.
 1SG.DAT LE broke.3SG the radio
 c. Se me le rompió la radio.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE broke.3SG the radio
 (12) a. Se me hundió el bote.
 SE 1SG.DAT sank.3SG the boat
 ‘The boat sank for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally sank the boat.’
 b. Me le hundió el bote.
 DAT.1SG LE sank.3SG the boat
 c. Se me le hundió el bote.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE sank.3SG the boat

The alternation may also be attested with a small series of unaccusative verbs that may combine with SE to acquire an inchoative interpretation, e.g., *caer* ‘fall’, *morir* ‘die’.

- (13) a. Se me cayeron las llaves.
SE 1SG.DAT fell.3PL the keys
'The keys fell for/on/to me.'
'I unintentionally dropped the keys.'
- b. Me le cayeron las llaves.
1SG.DAT LE fell.3PL the keys
- c. Se me le cayeron las llaves.
SE 1SG.DAT LE fell.3PL the keys
- (14) a. Se me murió la planta.
SE 1SG.DAT died.3SG the plant
'The plant died for/on/to me.'
'I unintentionally killed the plant.'
- b. Me le murió la planta.
1SG.DAT LE died.3SG the plant
- c. Se me le murió la planta.
SE 1SG.DAT LE died.3SG the plant

Lastly, stylistic *LE* also appears with psych-verbs formed with *SE* that have a dative experiencer, e.g., *olvidarse* 'forget' and *ocurrirse* 'occur'. These predicates behave like type III psych-verbs in the classification of Belletti & Rizzi (1988), i.e., they are unaccusative. The key property distinguishing them from prototypical type III predicates is that they are dynamic rather than stative (Fábregas & Marín 2020).

- (15) a. Se me olvidó eso.
SE 1SG.DAT forgot.3SG that
'I forgot that.'
- b. Me le olvidó eso.
1SG.DAT LE forgot.3SG that
- c. Se me le olvidó eso.
SE 1SG.DAT LE forgot.3SG that
- (16) a. Se me ocurrió una idea.
SE 1SG.DAT occurred.3SG a idea
'An idea occurred to me.'
- b. Me le ocurrió una idea.
1SG.DAT LE occurred.3SG a idea
- c. Se me le ocurrió una idea.
SE 1SG.DAT LE occurred.3SG a idea

Other grammatical contexts do not admit the stylistic *LE* alternation. Thus, for instance, verbs whose lexical entry includes the reflexive element *SE* but have an external argument, e.g., *quejarse* 'complain', also allow to create clitic clusters of the form *SE+CL_{dat}*, just as all examples discussed so far. However, introducing *LE* in these configurations produces unacceptable outcomes, i.e., replacing the sequence *se me* in (17a) for the clusters *me le* as in (17b) or *se me le* as in (17c) leads to ungrammaticality.

- (17) a. Cosmo se me quejó.
Cosmo SE 1SG.DAT complained.3SG
'Cosmo complained to me.'
- b. *Cosmo me le quejó (a mí).
Cosmo 1SG.DAT LE complained.3SG to me
- c. *Cosmo se me le quejó (a mí).
Cosmo SE 1SG.DAT LE complained.3SG to me

The same effect is attested with other grammatical configurations that surface as *SE+CL_{dat}* but do not combine marked anticausatives and affected datives. For example, the sentence in (18a) exhibits an

instance of impersonal *SE* plus a core argumental dative.³ Just as before, replacing the sequence *se me* in this example for *me le* or *se me le* leads to deviant results, e.g., (18b) and (18c).

- (18) a. No se me dio ni un peso.
not SE DAT.1SG gave.3SG not.even a peso
'No money was given to me.'
- b. *No me le dio ni un peso.
not DAT.1SG LE gave.3SG not.even a peso
- c. *No se me le dio ni un peso.
not SE DAT.1SG LE gave.3SG not.even a peso

The restrictions attested in (17) and (18) demonstrate that stylistic *LE* is not merely a phenomenon based on the phonological properties of certain clitic clusters. Instead, it seems to rely on grammatical mechanisms accessing core aspects of the underlying morphosyntactic representation.

The distribution of stylistic *LE* is further constrained by the φ -features of the corresponding dative argument. That is, the alternation is only attested with 1SG and 2SG dative clitics, e.g., (19) and (20). All other dative pronouns reject the presence of stylistic *LE*. This is illustrated in (21) for 3SG, (22) for 1PL, and (23) for both 2PL and 3PL (which are syncretic in American Spanish).

- (19) a. Se me cerró la ventana.
SE 1SG.DAT closed.3SG the window
'The window closed for/on/to me.'
'I unintentionally closed the window.'
- b. Me le cerró la ventana.
1SG.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
- c. Se me le cerró la ventana.
SE 1SG.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
- (20) a. Se te cerró la ventana.
SE 2SG.DAT closed.3SG the window
'The window closed for/on/to you.'
'You unintentionally closed the window.'
- b. Te le cerró la ventana.
2SG.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
- c. Se te le cerró la ventana.
SE 2SG.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
- (21) a. Se le cerró la ventana.
SE 3SG.DAT closed.3SG the window
'The window closed for/on/to her/him.'
'She/he unintentionally closed the window.'
- b. *Le le cerró la ventana.
3SG.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
- c. *Se le le cerró la ventana.
SE 3SG.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
- (22) a. Se nos cerró la ventana.
SE 1PL.DAT closed.3SG the window
'The window closed for/on/to us.'
'We unintentionally closed the window.'
- b. *Nos le cerró la ventana.
1PL.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
- c. *Se nos le cerró la ventana.
SE 1PL.DAT LE closed.3SG the window

³See Pujalte (2012) for discussion on the distinction between argumental and non-argumental datives in Spanish.

- (23) a. Se les cerró la ventana.
 SE 2/3PL.DAT closed.3SG the window
 ‘The window closed for/on/to you/them.’
 ‘You/they unintentionally closed the window.’
 b. *Les le cerró la ventana.
 2/3PL.DAT LE closed.3SG the window
 c. *Se les le cerró la ventana.
 SE 2/3PL.DAT LE closed.3SG the window

For completeness, the data in (24) illustrate two properties of stylistic *LE* patterns that are also attested with standard object clitics. First, while all cases of stylistic *LE* exemplified so far occupy proclitic positions, this element can also be enclitic; the sentence in (24a) shows that the cluster containing stylistic *LE* becomes enclitic when associated to a non-finite verb. Second, the referential dative pronoun appearing together with stylistic *LE* can be doubled, e.g., (24b); since the dative pronoun can only be 1SG or 2SG, the doubling patterns are restricted to the phrases *a mí* ‘to me’ or *a tí/voh* ‘to you’.

- (24) a. Van a caer-te-le las llaves.
 go.3PL to fall-2SG.DAT-LE the keys
 ‘The keys will fall for/on/to you.’
 ‘You will unintentionally drop the keys.’
 b. A mí (se) me le ocurrió la idea.
 DAT me SE 1SG.DAT LE occurred.3SG the idea
 ‘The idea occurred to me.’

The examples presented thus far illustrate the basic pattern and distribution of stylistic *LE*. The next section discusses in some depth two puzzling properties emerging from these data.

3 Two revealing properties

Two intriguing characteristics of stylistic *LE* serve as empirical clues for developing an analysis of the construction. First, the pattern displays restrictions based on the φ -features of the dative argument, e.g., (21) to (23), that do not seem to follow from any known constraint on clitic clusters; in particular, there is no obvious reason for the sequence *nos le* in (22) to trigger ungrammaticality. Second, while anticausative sentences incorporating stylistic *LE* always have the same interpretation, the anticausative marker *SE* is not required to be in them; this suggests that *SE* has no defining role in determining the meaning of anticausative predicates. These aspects are developed in detail in the following subsections.

3.1 Restrictions based on the features of the dative argument

As shown in the examples from (19) to (23), the dative clitic immediately preceding stylistic *LE* can only bear 1SG or 2SG features; if the dative clitic is 3SG, 1PL or 2/3PL, the pattern yields unacceptable results. The relevant distribution is illustrated in simplified form in (25).

- (25) a. (Se) me le
 SE 1SG.DAT LE
 b. (Se) te le
 SE 2SG.DAT LE
 c. *(Se) le le
 SE 3SG.DAT LE
 d. *(Se) nos le
 SE 1PL.DAT LE
 e. *(Se) les le
 SE 2/3PL.DAT LE

A null hypothesis regarding this distribution is that it follows from general syntactic constraints applying on clitic clusters rather than on specific properties of the construction. To begin with, some of the

unacceptable patterns in (25) could be accounted for in terms of syntactic haplology, i.e., a ban against adjacent identical elements (van Riemsdijk 2008, Nevins 2012, Neeleman & van de Koot 2017, i.a.). Neeleman & van de Koot (2017) discuss several examples of this restriction. One of them, originally observed by Bonet (1995), involves the Italian data in (26). Basically, the examples in (26a) and (26b) suggest that the impersonal clitic pronoun *si* and the reflexive clitic *se/si* should be able to form the sequence *si si*.⁴ However, this cluster is unacceptable, e.g., (26c), arguably because these elements are too similar to surface one next to the other within the same clitic cluster. Instead, the relevant meaning is expressed through the sequence *ci si* in (26d).⁵

- (26) a. Lo si sveglia.
him one wakes.up
'One wakes him up.'
- b. Se lo compra.
self it buys
'He/she buys it for himself/herself.'
- c. *Si si lava.
one self washes
'One washes oneself.'
- d. Ci si lava.
we self washes
'One washes oneself.'

The unacceptability of the Chilean Spanish clusters *le le* in (25c) and *les le* in (25e) could be accounted for in an analogous fashion. That is, these cases might be deviant simply because they contain sequences of two clitics that are “too similar” to each other, i.e., stylistic *LE* cannot be adjacent to a third person dative clitic because they are identical in some relevant regard. As noticed by Bonet (1995), among others, the identity criterion at play here cannot be formulated in phonological terms only. In the absence of a more precise definition, the fact that both elements are clitics associated to the realization of a non-core dative argument might suffice to consider them identical.

Suppose, for the sake of argument, that (25c) and (25e) can be ruled-out in terms of syntactic haplology. In that case, accounting for the distribution of stylistic *LE* in (25) reduces to explain the unacceptability of *nos le* in (25d). This is where the problem becomes particularly challenging, as there seems to be no known constraint allowing to capture both the unacceptability of *nos le* in (25d) and the acceptability of *me le* in (25a). To illustrate the complexity of the issue, consider the (weak version of the) *Person Case Constraint* (PCC), a well known condition on clitic clusters.

(27) PERSON CASE CONSTRAINT (Bonet 1991: 181)

In a combination of a weak direct object and an indirect object, if there is a third person it has to be the direct object.

The PCC successfully captures the unacceptability of a sequence of clitics of the form *nos le* in ditransitive constructions, as the cluster involves a first person direct object (i.e., *nos*) and a third person indirect object (i.e., *le*).

- (28) *Ella nos le recomendó.
she 1PL.ACC 3SG.DAT recommended
'She recommended us to her/him.'

However, the PCC cannot be the restriction behind the unacceptability of *nos le* in (25d). If this were the case, the analysis would wrongly predict the ungrammaticality of *me le* in (25a) as well. That is, a standard ditransitive sentence combining a 1SG direct object (i.e., *me*) and a 3SG indirect object (i.e., *le*) into the sequence *me le* is also expected to violate the PCC, e.g., (29). Thus, if we posit that the PCC

⁴As noticed by Bonet (1995: 609), the difference in vowel quality between (26b) and (26c), i.e., the reflexive being pronounced as *si* instead of *se*, is irrelevant to the issue under discussion.

⁵For a proposal that accounts for the distribution of Spanish clitics in contexts of clitic climbing in terms of haplology, see Villa-García (2019).

accounts for the distribution of stylistic *LE*, this would fail to capture the acceptability contrast between (25a) and (25d).⁶

- (29) *Ella me le recomendó.
 she 1SG.ACC 3SG.DAT recommended
 ‘She recommended me to her/him.’

Rivero (2008) proposes a further condition governing the functioning of clitic clusters: the *Quirky Person Restriction*. It establishes that first and second person reflexives cannot combine with third person dative clitics. She illustrates the effects of this constraint with examples involving plural reflexives: as can be

⁶An anonymous reviewer points out a different way of interpreting the restriction in relation to the PCC. They suggest that stylistic *LE* may involve what Bosse et al. (2012) call an *attitude holder* (or *ethical*) dative. As is known since Bonet (1991: 63–64), these elements are immune to the PCC, which could explain why the clitic cluster in (25a) is well-formed.

While Chilean Spanish does have attitude holder datives, e.g., *me* in (i), the type of construction under discussion here is the one Bosse et al. (2012) term an *affected experiencer* dative, e.g., *me* in (4b).

- (i) El niño no me come.
 the boy not DAT.1SG eat.3SG
 ‘The boy does not eat on me.’

The distinction between these dative elements is corroborated by the fact that they can co-occur in the same sentence (Cuervo 2003: 177); in (ii), *me* is an attitude holder, while *le* is an affected experiencer.

- (ii) Me le arruinaron la vida a mi hijo.
 DAT.1SG DAT.3SG the life DAT my son
 ‘They ruined my son’s life on me.’

Although both types of dative are superficially similar, they differ semantically. Only affected experiencers convey truth-conditional meanings: they refer to entities that are actually affected by the event, rather than merely emotionally involved, as is the case with attitude holder datives. As a consequence, a key syntactic difference arises: only affected experiencers can be questioned, e.g., (iii) vs. (iv).

- (iii) *¿A quién no le come el niño?
 DAT who not DAT.1SG eat.3SG the boy
 ‘On whom doesn’t the boy eat?’
 (iv) ¿A quién le abrió la puerta Cosmo?
 DAT who 3SG.DAT opened.3SG the door Cosmo
 ‘For/on/to whom did Cosmo open the door?’

The sentences that are the focus of this article, i.e., those combining anticausative *SE* and a non-core dative argument, allow questioning the dative argument, e.g., (v). This shows that the predicates in which stylistic *LE* appears involve affected experiencers rather than attitude holders.

- (v) ¿A quién se le abrió la puerta?
 DAT who SE 3SG.DAT opened.3SG the door
 ‘For/on/to whom did the door open?’
 ‘Who unintentionally opened the door?’

The same test cannot be directly replicated with stylistic *LE* since the dative argument in this construction must be first or second person, whereas wh-phrases are third person only. Nonetheless, other properties of attitude holder datives make it possible to distinguish them from stylistic *LE* sentences. As discussed by Cuervo (2003: 174–175), attitude holder datives cannot be doubled by a strong pronominal DP, e.g., (vi). By contrast, this is perfectly possible with the dative argument in stylistic *LE* sentences, e.g., (vii) and (24b). Moreover, the example in (vii) can be used as an answer to (v), which shows that the affected experiencer DP can be focused and, therefore, is part of the asserted proposition.

- (vi) *El niño no me come a mí.
 the boy not DAT.1SG eat.3SG DAT me
 ‘The boy does not eat ON ME.’
 (vii) (Se) me le abrió la puerta a mí.
 SE DAT.1SG LE opened.3SG the door DAT me
 ‘The door opened for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally opened the door.’

seen in (30a), pairing the third person reflexive clitic *se* and the third person dative clitic *le* is fully acceptable in Spanish; however, if the reflexive is instead the 1PL form *nos*, as in (30b), the result is deviant. Given that Rivero’s constraint precludes the formation of a clitic cluster of the form *nos le*, it could be responsible for the unacceptability of (25d).

- (30) a. A Cosmo *se le* olvidaron ellos.
 DAT Cosmo 3.REFL 3SG.DAT forgot.3PL they.NOM
 ‘Cosmo forgot about them.’
 b. *A Cosmo *nos le* olvidamos nosotros.
 DAT Cosmo 1PL.REFL 3SG.DAT forgot.1PL we.NOM
 ‘Cosmo forgot about us.’

However, just as the PCC before, the Quirky Person Restriction does not allow to explain the acceptability contrast between (25a) and (25d). While Rivero’s observations are based on data involving plural reflexives only, the restriction she proposes should apply as well to 1SG and 2SG reflexives. In particular, it correctly predicts that the 1SG reflexive *me* cannot combine with *le*, e.g., (31). Since this prediction is incorrect for *me le* in (25a), it follows that the Quirky Person Restriction is not the principle behind the distribution of stylistic *LE*.

- (31) *A Cosmo *me le* olvidé yo.
 DAT Cosmo 1SG.REFL 3SG.DAT forgot.1SG I.NOM
 ‘Cosmo forgot about me.’

The fact that neither the PCC nor the Quirky Person Restriction captures the distribution of clitics in (25) does not mean that there is anything wrong with these conditions; rather, it says something about the nature of stylistic *LE*. Both conditions rule out the combination of certain types of elements with a dative clitic pronoun. The reason they fail to capture the behavior of stylistic *LE* may simply be that this element, despite appearances, is not a pronoun at all.

As mentioned earlier, stylistic *LE* lacks the denotational properties of standard dative pronouns, i.e., it does not refer to a participant of the event or to a discourse referent. This can be seen in the complete synonymy between sentences containing stylistic *LE* and their counterparts exhibiting the standard *SE+CL_{dat}* cluster: the presence or absence of *LE* leaves truth conditions and argument structure unaffected. In this sense, *LE* seems to function as a purely formal exponent rather than as a pronominal argument.

The semantic contrast between standard dative clitics and stylistic *LE* has grammatical consequences. For instance, while dative clitics in ditransitive constructions can be correferential with a doubling DP, e.g., (32), stylistic *LE* systematically disallows this possibility, e.g., (33).

- (32) *Le* abrió la puerta a Cosmo.
 DAT.3SG opened.3SG the doors DAT Cosmo
 ‘She/he opened the door for/on/to Cosmo.’
 (33) a. **Me le* abrió la puerta a Cosmo.
 DAT.1SG LE opened.3SG the doors DAT Cosmo
 Intended: ‘I unintentionally opened the doors for/on/to Cosmo.’
 b. **Se me le* abrió la puerta a Cosmo.
 SE DAT.1SG LE opened.3SG the doors DAT Cosmo
 Intended: ‘I unintentionally opened the doors for/on/to Cosmo.’

Moreover, while standard dative pronouns inflect for Number, e.g., (34), stylistic *LE* is morphologically invariable, e.g., (35). This further supports the claim that stylistic *LE* is not a pronoun.

- (34) *Se les* abrieron las puertas.
 SE DAT.3PL opened.3SG the doors
 ‘The doors opened for/on/to them.’
 ‘They unintentionally opened the doors.’

- (35) a. *Me les abrieron las puertas.
 DAT.1SG LE.PL opened.3SG the doors
 ‘The doors opened for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally opened the doors.’
 b. *Se me les abrieron las puertas.
 SE DAT.1SG LE.PL opened.3SG the doors
 ‘The door opened for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally opened the doors.’

The interim conclusion seems to be that general conditions on clitic clusters such as the PCC and the Quirky Person Restriction do not account for the distribution of dative arguments with respect to stylistic *LE*. In particular, these conditions fail to apply because stylistic *LE*, although it has the shape as a dative pronoun, is arguably not one. The upshot is that the patterns in (25) must be captured by appealing to construction-specific properties and mechanisms that treat *LE* as something other than a dative pronoun.

3.2 Presence and absence of *SE*

As mentioned in the introduction, a line of analysis for anticausative *SE* involves the assumption that this element is responsible for the anticausative interpretation of the predicate. A specific implementation of this intuition is due to Chierchia (2004) and Koontz-Garboden (2009). The core idea of their proposal is that anticausative predicates obtain through a process of reflexivization. That is, they maintain that the relation between a causative verb and its anticausative counterpart is identical to the relation between transitive and reflexive predicates: it is mediated by the semantic contribution of a reflexive element such as *SE*.

Reflexivization can be understood as a semantic operation that co-identifies two arguments of a predicate. Thus, a reflexive element like *SE* would take as an argument a relation $\mathfrak{R}$ between two elements and return the set of pairs in which these elements are identical. Koontz-Garboden (2009: 83) formalizes this idea as in (36).

$$(36) \llbracket se \rrbracket = \lambda \mathfrak{R}. \lambda x. \mathfrak{R}(x, x)$$

To exemplify, consider the causative form of the verb *abrir* ‘open’. As can be seen in (37), it denotes a relation between two arguments x and y , in which some action or property β of y causes x to be open.

$$(37) \llbracket abrir \rrbracket = \lambda x. \lambda y. \exists \beta [\beta(y) \text{ causes open}(x)] \quad \text{causative verb}$$

According to the theory of Chierchia (2004) and Koontz-Garboden (2009), the semantic contribution of *SE* equates to co-identifying both arguments. That is, the anticausative marker is an element that takes the externally caused event in (37) and turns it into the internally caused event in (38), in which some relevant property of the theme argument x is interpreted as playing a role in the change of state of x .

$$(38) \llbracket abrirse \rrbracket = \lambda x. \exists \beta [\beta(x) \text{ causes open}(x)] \quad \text{anticausative verb}$$

As a result, an anticausative sentence like (2b), repeated for convenience in (39), receives a reading akin to “some property of the door caused it to become open”.

- (39) La puerta se abrió.
 the door SE opened.3SG
 ‘The door opened.’

This theory elegantly derives both the semantics of anticausative predicates and the observation that reflexive and anticausative morphological markings tend to be the same. In particular, the explanation relies on the semantic import of a constituent appearing in both types of construction.

This proposal encounters a significant problem when applied to examples involving stylistic *LE*. As discussed, this element surfaces with marked anticausative predicates; this is corroborated by the fact that all relevant examples allow interpreting the dative argument as an unintentional causer, e.g., (40).

Despite this, the sentence in (40b) does not exhibit the reflexive element *SE* that is supposed to be responsible for its anticausative interpretation.⁷ Therefore, it provides straightforward evidence against the thesis that *SE* is instrumental for the semantics of the construction.⁸

- (40) a. Se me abrió la puerta.
SE 1SG.DAT opened.3SG the door
'The door opened for/on/to me.'
'I unintentionally opened the door.'
- b. Me le abrió la puerta.
1SG.DAT LE opened.3SG the door
- c. Se me le abrió la puerta.
SE 1SG.DAT LE opened.3SG the door

In principle, the theory by Chierchia (2004) and Koontz-Garboden (2009) could deal with the absence of *SE* in (40b) by assuming that the reflexive element in this sentence is phonologically null. Chierchia (2004: 41–42) argues that in anticausative predicates with no *SE*-marking “the reflexive operator is lexically incorporated into the meaning of the verb without any morphological reflex”. In principle, this idea accounts for verbs such as *hervir* ‘boil’ in (1) or *mejorar* ‘improve’ in (41), which participate in the causative alternation without introducing any morphological markings in the anticausative variant. That is, the anticausative interpretation of (41b) obtains from a null reflexive that has been integrated into the semantics of the verb.⁹

- (41) a. Los dueños de la empresa mejoraron los sueldos.
the owners of the company improved.3SG the salaries
'The owners of the company improved the salaries.'
- b. Los sueldos mejoraron.
the salaries improved.3PL
'The salaries improved.'

The same type of logic could be applied to account for (40b): perhaps *SE* does not surface in this example because its anticausative meaning is already incorporated into the verb.

This solution, however, is inadequate for the stylistic *LE* phenomenon. There are two main reasons for this. First, such an analysis blurs the strong distinction between marked and unmarked anticausative verbs. That is, since every verb admitting stylistic *LE* allows for the alternations in (40), then null reflexives would have to be optional in order to capture that *SE* is silent in (40b) but overt in (40)c. This does not fit the behavior of anticausative predicates in Spanish: while some verbs exhibit some marginal optionality regarding *SE*-marking (see example (47) below), anticausative verbs generally either require *SE* or they do not. For instance, the verb *mejorar* ‘improve’, which is an unmarked anticausative, rejects the presence of *SE*, e.g., (42).

- (42) * Los sueldos se mejoraron.
the salaries SE improved.3PL
'The salaries improved.'

Similarly, a verb like *quebrar* ‘crack’, which is a marked anticausative, cannot form anticausative predicates without *SE*, e.g., (43).

- (43) a. Cosmo quebró el florero.
Cosmo cracked.3SG the flower.vase
'Cosmo cracked the flower vase.'

⁷Thus, *SE* is truly optional in stylistic *LE* contexts, in contrast to the seemingly optional instances of *SE* attested in other Romance languages, e.g., Asturian; see Suárez-Palma (2021) for discussion.

⁸For further arguments against the reflexivization analysis of anticausatives, see Horvath & Siloni (2011), Alexiadou et al. (2015), and Schäfer & Vivanco (2016).

⁹This aspect of the theory is part of Chierchia’s (2004) version. In Koontz-Garboden’s (2009) implementation, only *SE*-marked anticausatives involve reflexivization.

- b. *El florero quebró.
 the flower.vase cracked.3SG
 ‘The flower vase cracked.’
- c. El florero se quebró.
 the flower.vase SE cracked.3SG
 ‘The flower vase cracked.’

Thus, marked and unmarked anticausative verbs belong to mostly well-defined classes. Assuming that examples such as (40b) incorporate null reflexives in the same way as unmarked anticausatives do goes against this observation.

A second argument for rejecting an analysis of (40b) in terms of a null reflexive comes from the behavior of stylistic *LE* itself. The idea that unmarked anticausatives recruit a silent version of *SE* relies on the assumption that marked and unmarked anticausatives have a parallel underlying representation allowing them to undergo the same morphosyntactic processes, e.g., reflexivization. The stylistic *LE* alternation provides evidence against this assumption: only *SE*-marked verbs like *quebrar* ‘crack’ license stylistic *LE*, e.g., (44). Unmarked anticausative verbs such as *mejorar* ‘improve’ cannot host this element (45). Given this stark contrast, the hypothesis that stylistic *LE* sentences lacking *SE*, e.g., (40b) and (44b), are anticausative due to the same process as unmarked anticausative sentences, e.g., (41b) and (44a), becomes untenable: if there were a null *SE* in both (44b) and (45b), why is only the latter unacceptable?

- (44) a. Se me quebró el florero.
 SE 1SG.DAT cracked.3SG the flower.vase
 ‘The flower vase cracked for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally cracked the flower vase.’
- b. Me le quebró el florero.
 1SG.DAT LE cracked.3SG the flower.vase
- c. Se me le quebró el florero.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE cracked.3SG the flower.vase
- (45) a. Me mejoró el sueldo.
 1SG.DAT improved.3SG the salary
 ‘The salary improved for/on/to me.’
- b. *Me le mejoró el sueldo.
 1SG.DAT LE improved.3SG the salary

Further evidence that marked and unmarked anticausatives are different for the purposes of the stylistic *LE* alternation comes from the peculiar behavior of verbs such as *hervir* ‘boil’. As already shown in (1), repeated for convenience in (46), this verb typically does not require *SE* to participate in the causative alternation.

- (46) a. Cosmo hirvió el agua.
 Cosmo boiled.3SG the water
 ‘Cosmo boiled the water.’
- b. El agua hirvió.
 the water boiled.3SG
 ‘The water boiled.’

However, *hervir* ‘boil’ does exhibit some optionality regarding its anticausative marking: as can be seen in (47), it is marginally possible to add *SE* to it to produce an anticausative predicate.

- (47) ?El agua se hirvió.
 the water SE boiled.3SG
 ‘The water boiled.’

Both anticausative predicates in (46b) and (47) may combine with affected datives with different results: only the *SE*-marked variant in (48b) triggers the unintentional causer interpretation.¹⁰ Unmarked anticausatives combined with affected datives never make this reading available in Spanish; the same effect is attested with (45a). The contrast fits well within the traditional observation that marked anticausatives express externally caused changes-of-state, while unmarked anticausatives express internally driven changes-of-state (e.g., Martin 2023): in principle, only the former should be able to license accidental causers.

- (48) a. Me hirvió el agua.
 1SG.DAT boiled.3SG the water
 ‘The water boiled for/on/to me.’
 b. Se me hirvió el agua.
 SE 1SG.DAT boiled.3SG the water
 ‘The water boiled for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally boiled the water.’

Since (48b) combines anticausative *SE* and an affected dative, it is able to host stylistic *LE*, e.g., (49). Interestingly enough, the variant that does not include *SE* in (49a) is interpreted just as if *SE* was part of its structure, i.e., it is synonymous with (48b) rather than (48a). This, once again, proves that examples such as (49a) cannot be equated with unmarked anticausatives and, therefore, they do not involve null reflexives.

- (49) a. Me le hirvió el agua.
 1SG.DAT LE boiled.3SG the water
 ‘The water boiled for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally boiled the water.’
 b. Se me le hirvió el agua.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE boiled.3SG the water

At least two conclusions can be drawn from these data points. First, the fact that stylistic *LE* appears only with marked anticausative verbs shows that some aspect of their grammatical representation triggers the emergence of this element; this may point to a difference in the syntactic makeup of marked and unmarked anticausative predicates. Second, stylistic *LE* makes the presence of *SE* optional: the construction preserves the same interpretation no matter this element is present or not in the sentence. As discussed, this optionality cannot be equated with the distinction between marked and unmarked anticausatives, and therefore posits a straightforward challenge to any theory that hinges on the assumption that *SE* is an essential component of anticausative semantics.

4 Proposal

The conclusion of the previous section allows us to posit a very plain conjecture: if there are sentences that have the same interpretation with and without anticausative *SE*, then it must be the case that this element is devoid of meaning. In other words, the optionality of *SE* in pairs such as (44b) and (44c) suggests that *SE* is a semantically vacuous marker fulfilling a purely formal role in anticausative predicates.

This section develops an analysis of the stylistic *LE* phenomenon along these lines. The basic idea is that the sequences of clitics *me le* and *te le* arise from a “splitting” operation that distributes the features normally realized on a single element across two exponents; that is, stylistic *LE* involves *extended* or *multiple exponence* (Matthews 1974, Harris 2017). Crucially, since one clitic in the sequence has the shape of a reflexive, it is able to fulfill the role of an anticausative marker, rendering the syntactic insertion of *SE* unnecessary. The core insight, then, is that anticausative marking can be handled at the surface level, provided the appropriate exponents are available.

¹⁰The subjects in the examples in (48) are postverbal. This is because the SV order in the first sentence, i.e., *el agua me hirvió*, has the preferred interpretation of ‘the water boiled me’. While this reading is still available in (48a), it is less salient and allows for an easier inspection of the relevant meaning.

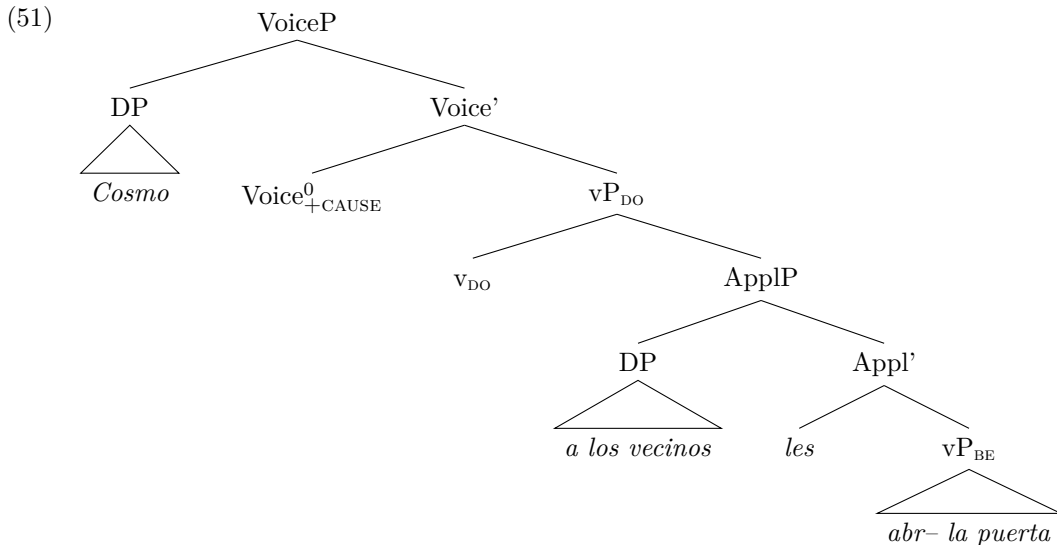
In principle, the analysis will focus on verbs that participate in the causative alternation through *SE*-marking, e.g., (11) and (12). Section 5 will discuss later how the proposal can be extended to account for unaccusative verbs with *SE*, e.g., (13) and (14), and for psychological predicates combining dative experiencers and *SE*, e.g., (15) and (16).

4.1 Assumptions on the syntax of affected experiencers and anticausative *SE*

I take that non-core dative arguments in Spanish are introduced through applicative heads (Cuervo 2003, Pujalte 2012, i.a.). According to this, a dative DP expressing a non-core argument merges in the specifier position of a projection ApplP; the dative clitic associated to this DP is the realization of the functional head Appl⁰. The interpretation of these elements depends on the position of ApplP in the syntactic spine. In particular, dative arguments interpreted as affected entities are *high applicatives* in the terminology of Pytkänen (2008), i.e., they result from ApplP dominating the lexical projection of the verb. More generally, I adopt the scheme proposed by Cuervo (2003: 113) as the basic blueprint for predicates with affected datives. To illustrate, take the sentence in (50).

- (50) Cosmo les abrió la puerta a los vecinos.
 Cosmo 3PL.DAT open.3SG the door DAT the neighbors
 ‘Cosmo opened the door for the neighbors.’

The structure in (51) depicts the analysis of this example according to Cuervo (2003). In her proposal, the applicative head surfacing as the 3PL dative clitic *les* combines with a vP_{BE} denoting a state (i.e., the door being open), while ApplP is selected by a head v_{DO} introducing a dynamic subevent; the combination of v_{DO} and v_{BE} result in the bi-eventive configuration proper of causative predicates; see Cuervo (2003) for motivation and discussion of these verbal projections.



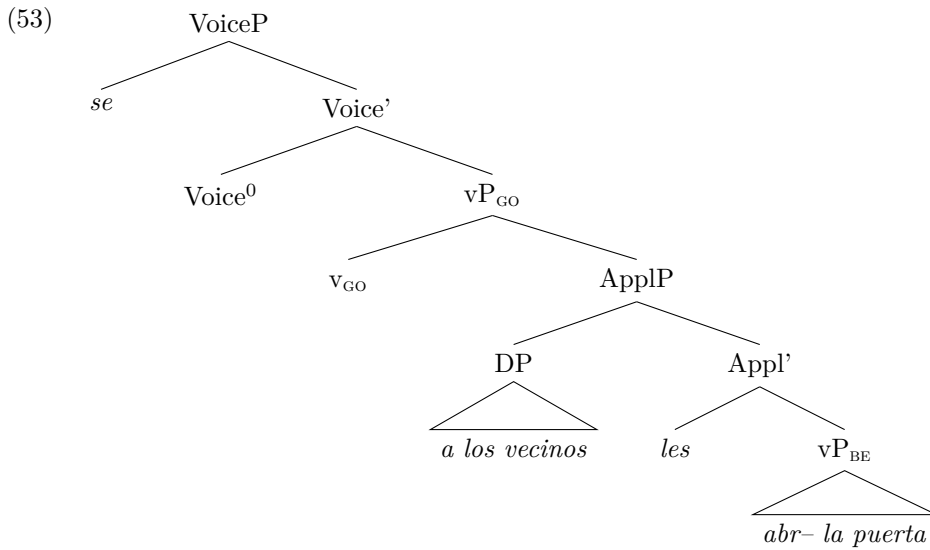
To discuss the structure of anticausative predicates, take the sentence in (52), which replaces the subject *Cosmo* in (50) for the anticausative marker *SE*.

- (52) Se les abrió la puerta a los vecinos.
 SE 3PL.DAT open.3SG the door DAT the neighbors
 ‘The door opened for/on/to the neighbors.’
 ‘The neighbors unintentionally opened the door.’

The hypothesis to explore here is that the anticausative marker is devoid of semantic content and contributes no meaning to this sentence; instead, it merely satisfies a formal requirement of some anticausative predicates, which are required to overtly signal the absence of an external argument. This assimilates the functioning of anticausative markers to that of expletive pronouns, i.e., both are dummy

objects whose only purpose is to fill a slot in the grammatical representation. Such an approach to anticausative markers has been advanced in different ways by Schäfer (2008), Pujalte & Saab (2012), Wood (2014), Alexiadou et al. (2015), Saab (2020), among others; for concreteness, I will adapt the theory in Schäfer (2008) for the remainder discussion.

Schäfer’s (2008) theory revolves around the properties of the VoiceP projection. As is known, Voice is a functional head that introduces a causer in its specifier position (Kratzer 1996). For instance, for the proper noun *Cosmo* to be understood as the agent of (50a), it needs to be selected as the specifier of VoiceP as shown in (51b). According to Schäfer (2008) and other authors, anticausative predicates recruit a semantically vacuous instance of Voice, i.e., they contain a version of the head that does not introduce a causer. Such a dummy version of Voice, however, still requires a constituent in its specifier position due to its purely formal subcategorization features. By assumption, a reflexive pronoun is introduced in this position as an expletive-like element; Schäfer (2008) speculates that reflexives are particularly well-suited to fulfill this function as they are inherently non-referential. Thus, according to the assumptions adopted so far, an anticausative predicate like the one in (52) receives the schematic analysis in (53b), with the reflexive *SE* being inserted in the specifier position of VoiceP.^{11,12}



Notice that the scheme in (53) also differs from (51) in terms of the higher vP layer in the structure. That is, while (51) includes a head v_{DO} , (53) incorporates v_{GO} in the same position. In Cuervo’s (2003) system, v_{GO} introduces a subevent of change. While appearing typically in unaccusative predicates, v_{GO} may combine with v_{BE} as in (53) to compose inchoative events.

A final assumption concerns the meanings arising from the representation in (53). I take that the non-core dative argument in this structure can be interpreted either as an affected entity (i.e., with the reading ‘the door opened for the neighbors’), or as an unintentional causer (i.e., with the reading ‘the neighbors unintentionally opened the door’). This clarification is necessary as authors like Cuervo (2003, 2020) and Schäfer (2008) conjecture that these interpretations stem from two distinct syntactic structures. While such hypothesis could be compatible with the proposal to be developed here, adopting it would increase the complexity of the analysis without gaining any empirical coverage.

Consider the sentences in (54). As can be seen, they are all ambiguous between the two interpretations.

¹¹The structure in (53) departs from Cuervo’s (2003) assumptions in two regards. First, she takes *SE* to be the realization of the head v_{GO} . Second, she maintains that vP_{GO} does not require a VoiceP projection. This latter claim seems compatible with the idea that anticausatives incorporate a semantically vacuous flavor of $Voice^0$: in both cases, the causer-introducing meaning is absent from the representation.

¹²Anticausative *SE* is a *paradigmatic* element. To capture this property, I follow Saab (2020) in assuming that *SE* is a *Probe* in the sense of Chomsky (2001), i.e., it establishes agreement with a DP in its c-command domain. While the morphological variation of *SE* is not instrumental for the analysis developed here, noting it is crucial for a complete grammatical description of the anticausative construction.

- (54) a. Se me cortó la correa.
 SE 1SG.DAT snapped.3SG the strap
 ‘The strap snapped for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally snapped the strap.’
 b. Me le cortó la correa.
 1SG.DAT LE snapped.3SG the strap
 c. Se me le cortó la correa.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE snapped.3SG the strap

While the verb *cortar* snap in (54) allows the 1SG dative pronoun *me* to be interpreted as an unintentional causer, this reading can be blocked by simply replacing the DP *la correa* the strap’ with the DP *la luz* the light, as in (55). The resulting interpretation is that the speaker experienced a power outage.

- (55) a. Se me cortó la luz.
 SE 1SG.DAT snapped.3SG the light
 ‘The power went out for/on/to me.’
 b. Me le cortó la luz.
 1SG.DAT LE snapped.3SG the light
 c. Se me le cortó la luz.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE snapped.3SG the light

The examples in (55) are not ambiguous. If the relevant interpretations relied on different underlying structures, then the unavailability of one of the readings should follow from the ungrammaticality of the corresponding syntactic representation. However, there is no obvious reason why replacing the lexical content of a DP would trigger ungrammaticality. The absence of the relevant interpretation in (55) rather seems to stem from world knowledge: the unintentional causer reading is unavailable in (55) simply because such a meaning would be implausible, as blackouts are spontaneous events. Thus, what determines the ambiguity of examples such as (54) is not their syntax, but what pragmatics can do with the compositional meaning of a structure such as (53).¹³ In short, the case for positing a distinct syntactic structure for the unintentional causer reading seems somewhat weak when considering the formal properties of the construction (at least for the Spanish data).

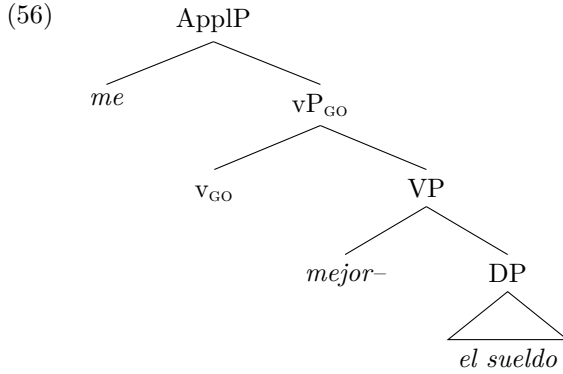
There are also practical reasons to disregard a separate syntactic representation for unintentional causers. On the one hand, the fact that a sentence can receive this type of interpretation is completely orthogonal to the stylistic *LE* phenomenon: as seen in previous examples, the alternation applies no matter whether this reading is available or not. On the other hand, this assumption would make the analysis unnecessarily more complex. Consider the following. The formal contrast attested in (55) already requires positing three individual analyses capturing each of the alternatives. If the ambiguity of each sentence is also to be explained in grammatical terms, then the pattern would require six analyses. This move would be justified if it allowed to capture some property of the construction but, as discussed, there seems to be no obvious empirical gain on pursuing this approach.

Structures like the one in (53) will be taken from now on as the base configuration over which the stylistic *LE* phenomenon applies. Therefore, unmarked anticausative predicates, which cannot host stylistic *LE*, e.g., (45), are assumed to have a different underlying representation. While I remain agnostic about the details of the analysis of these predicates, it is worth mentioning the characterization proposed for them

¹³ Similar effects can be observed with several idiomatic expressions. For instance, the idiom in (i) is used to tease someone who accidentally gives away their age by saying or doing something outdated. In this case, the unintentional causer reading is the only one that is available, even though the corresponding syntactic representations are arguably parallel to those in (54) in the relevant aspects.

- (i) a. Se te cayó el carnet.
 SE 2SG.DAT fell.3SG the identification.card
 ‘You unintentionally revealed your age.’
 b. Te le cayó el carnet.
 2SG.DAT LE fell.3SG the identification.card
 c. Se te le cayó el carnet.
 SE 2SG.DAT LE fell.3SG the identification.card

by Cuervo (2003). According to her, these involve mono-eventive structures lacking a vP_{BE} denoting a state. When an applicative argument is introduced in these predicates, e.g., (45a) and (48a), it occupies a position above the projection denoting the subevent of change vP_{GO} . The following scheme, based on Cuervo (2003: 162), illustrates a potential analysis for the example in (45a).

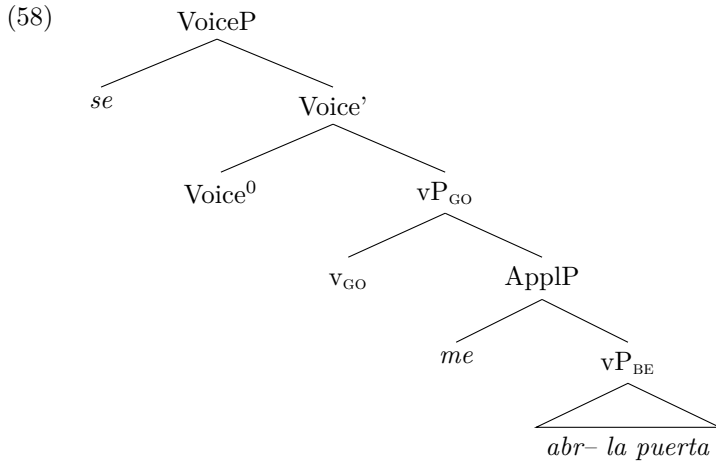


4.2 Stylistic *LE* as a product of multiple exponence

Let's consider again the initial data in (5) and (10), repeated for convenience in (57). As discussed, General Spanish generates a clitic cluster of the form $SE+CL_{dat}$ in contexts combining marked anticausatives and affected datives, e.g., *se me* in (57a). Chilean Spanish has two further ways of expressing the same meaning: a cluster $CL_{dat}+LE$, e.g., *me le* in (57b), or a cluster $SE+CL_{dat}+LE$, e.g., *se me le* in (57c).

- (57)
- a. *Se me abrió la puerta.*
 SE 1SG.DAT opened.3SG the door
 'The door opened for/on/to me.'
 'I unintentionally opened the door.'
 - b. *Me le abrió la puerta.*
 1SG.DAT LE opened.3SG the door
 'The door opened for/on/to me.'
 'I unintentionally opened the door.'
 - c. *Se me le abrió la puerta.*
 SE 1SG.DAT LE opened.3SG the door

The system depicted throughout subsection 4.1 allows to posit a syntactic analysis for (57a) in the same lines as (53). The relevant structure is depicted in (58). As can be seen, the 1SG clitic pronoun *me* is the realization of the applicative head, while *SE* is inserted in Spec,VoiceP to satisfy the subcategorization features of Voice⁰.



To account for the patterns in (57b) and (57c), it is necessary first to advance a hypothesis about what *LE* is in this type of sentences. There are a few clues that might lead to an answer. As already discussed, stylistic *LE* seems to contribute no new meaning to the sentence. While it resembles a 3SG dative pronoun, it is morphologically invariable and exhibits no referential properties. As seen, it surfaces exclusively next to a 1SG or 2SG dative clitic, forming in all cases the sequences *me le* or *te le*. Finally, it appears in predicates argued to involve applicative arguments.

I contend that the clitic sequences *me le* and *te le* found in the relevant examples are instances of *extended* or *multiple exponence* (Matthews 1974, Harris 2017); that is, they involve the realization of the properties of a single syntactic unit through two distinct morphological exponents. Intuitively, this process can be conceived as the splitting of an abstract element into two surface forms: *me* and *le* in some cases, and *te* and *le* in others. I propose that the element undergoing the “split” is the applicative head Appl⁰.

A simple way of making sense of this “split” is in terms of the role that can be attributed to each resulting exponent. Take again the sentence in (57a) with its corresponding syntactic structure in (58). In this example, the applicative head serves two functions simultaneously. On one hand, it is a functional element introducing a dative argument to the predicate. On the other, it is the dative argument itself; that is, it functions as a first person pronoun. In General Spanish, both roles collapse into a single exponent: the dative pronoun *me*. Chilean Spanish, however, displays the option of separating these functions into two dative-related elements: *LE* and *me*. The former is a pronoun-like form that merely signals the presence of an applicative head in the structure, while the latter is the argument introduced by the applicative head. These elements surface as the clitic sequence *me le*.

From a purely descriptive and theory-independent point of view, this amounts to assigning *LE* the role of an applicative marker: an invariable element whose sole function is to indicate that an adjacent dative pronoun must be interpreted as a (non-core) argument of the predicate. Therefore, rather than *stylistic LE*, a more general and language-neutral designation for the phenomenon under study in this article could be *stylistic applicative*.

Within the Distributed Morphology tradition, the type of multiple exponence described above is captured through the *Fission* operation (Noyer 1992, Halle & Marantz 1993, Halle 1997, Arregi & Nevins 2012, i.a.). Fission is a postsyntactic mechanism that takes a terminal node consisting of a bundle of features and splits it into two parts, each of them comprising features that co-occurred within the original node. The rule in (59) illustrates the mechanism.¹⁴

(59)

$$\begin{bmatrix} F_1 \\ F_2 \\ F_3 \\ F_4 \\ \dots \end{bmatrix} \rightarrow \begin{bmatrix} F_1 \\ F_2 \\ F_3 \\ \dots \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} F_2 \\ F_4 \\ \dots \end{bmatrix}$$

Adapting descriptions by Arregi & Nevins (2018), I propose that the applicative head undergoing the morphological split carries features that specify it as being a clitic (i.e., [−STRONG]), which is either 1SG or 2SG (i.e., [+PART], [±AUTHOR] and [+SING]), and has dative case (i.e., [DATIVE]). Fission distributes the features of this head into two exponents, *Cl₁* and *Cl₂*. *Cl₁* receives features that define it as a 1SG or 2SG clitic pronoun (i.e., [−STRONG], [+PART], [±AUTHOR] and [+SING]). *Cl₂*, on the other hand, keeps features that basically define it as an “inflectionless” dative clitic ([−STRONG] and [DATIVE]). Finally, I assume that this process takes place only if Appl⁰ is in the context of inchoative predicates containing both heads *v_{GO}* and *v_{BE}*. The rule in (60) provides a concise representation of this process.

¹⁴In an earlier version of this analysis, I followed the ideas in McGinnis’s (1995) and attempted to capture the effects of Fission within the syntactic component through *Feature Movement* (Hiemstra 1986, Cheng 2000, Sabel 2000, i.a.). The basic idea behind this mechanism is that syntactic movement can target a proper subset of the formal features of a constituent. Thus, a head β probing a feature on a constituent α may attract to Spec, β P a bundle of features of α ; since, as a result, the features of α are distributed across two separate nodes, both may receive independent pronunciation. Accordingly, to capture the splits sketched in (59), I hypothesized that the head *v_{GO}* attracted the set of φ -features of Appl⁰ to its specifier position, leaving behind a categorial feature [APPL]. The node with the φ -features was realized as the dative pronoun *me* or *te* (depending on the value of the Person feature), while the stranded [APPL] feature surfaced as the dative-like form *LE*. This version of the analysis was ultimately abandoned, however, since it introduced several theoretical inconsistencies that rendered the proposal untenable.

(60)

$$\begin{array}{c} \text{Appl}^0 \\ \left[\begin{array}{c} - \text{STRONG} \\ + \text{PART} \\ \pm \text{AUTHOR} \\ + \text{SING} \\ \text{DATIVE} \end{array} \right] \end{array} \rightarrow \begin{array}{c} \text{Cl}_1 \\ \left[\begin{array}{c} - \text{STRONG} \\ + \text{PART} \\ \pm \text{AUTHOR} \\ + \text{SING} \end{array} \right] \end{array} \begin{array}{c} \text{Cl}_2 \\ \left[\begin{array}{c} - \text{STRONG} \\ + \text{DATIVE} \end{array} \right] \end{array} / v_{\text{GO}} - v_{\text{BE}}$$

Once the morphological mechanism responsible for multiple exponence has been established, we can now develop an analysis of stylistic *LE* sentences that exhibit clitic clusters of the form *SE+Cl_{dat}+LE*. Consider again the example in (57c). This sentence contains the anticausative marker *SE*, which, as discussed in section 4.1, is introduced in the syntax as the specifier of VoiceP. I propose that stylistic *LE* sentences containing *SE* are derived from the same underlying syntactic structure as standard anticausative constructions with an affected dative but without *LE*, e.g., (57a); this accounts for why both patterns are identical in meaning. This means that the grammatical representation to which the Fission operation applies in order to derive (57c) is the one already schematized in (58).

When the features associated to the head *Appl*⁰ in (58) are sent to the morphological component, Fission splits them into two distinct exponents, resulting in the surface sequence *me le*. The first exponent spells-out the Person and Number features of the applicative head; the latter is, by assumption, the realization of a dative feature lacking Person and Number. The splitting operation is schematized in (61).

(61)

$$\begin{array}{c} \text{me} \\ \left[\begin{array}{c} - \text{STRONG} \\ + \text{PART} \\ + \text{AUTHOR} \\ + \text{SING} \\ \text{DATIVE} \end{array} \right] \end{array} \rightarrow \begin{array}{c} \text{me} \\ \left[\begin{array}{c} - \text{STRONG} \\ + \text{PART} \\ + \text{AUTHOR} \\ + \text{SING} \end{array} \right] \end{array} \begin{array}{c} \text{le} \\ \left[\begin{array}{c} - \text{STRONG} \\ + \text{DATIVE} \end{array} \right] \end{array} / v_{\text{GO}} - v_{\text{BE}}$$

The resulting exponents *me* and *le* combine with *SE* to form the clitic cluster *se me le* that surfaces in examples such as (57c). The whole clitic cluster can thus be regarded as a specific morphological realization of the VoiceP and ApplP projections in Chilean Spanish.

A final remark on the Fission rule in (60) is in order. The rule is selective in two regards. First, it restricts the elements to which it can apply. As can be seen in (60), its application is limited to heads bearing a specific set of features: [STRONG], [+PART], [±AUTHOR], [+SING], and [DATIVE]; as discussed, this feature bundle corresponds to the 1SG and 2SG instances of *Appl*⁰. This restriction correctly captures the distribution of stylistic *LE* with respect to the features of the dative argument. As shown earlier in (25), repeated for convenience in (62), stylistic *LE* is unattested with 3SG dative clitics, e.g. (62c), and with plural datives in general, e.g. (62d) and (62e). This follows straightforwardly if the Fission mechanisms fails to apply to applicative heads that either (i) lack a [+PART] feature and therefore do not encode discourse participants, or (ii) lack a [+SING] specification.

- (62) a. (Se) me le
b. (Se) te le
c. * (Se) le le *Appl*⁰ lacks [+PART]
d. * (Se) nos le *Appl*⁰ lacks [+SING]
e. * (Se) les le *Appl*⁰ lacks [+SING]

The second aspect in which the rule in (60) is selective concerns the structural contexts in which Fission can apply. Specifically, the operation requires an inchoative predicate derived from the combination of two subevents, a dynamic subevent of change and a stative subevent of result. Following Cuervo (2003), these subevents are introduced by the verbal heads *v_{GO}* and *v_{BE}*, respectively; this configuration is precisely the one invoked in the rule. As a consequence, stylistic *LE* cannot surface in configurations where the applicative head appears without this eventive structure; this includes unmarked anticausative verbs, which, under Cuervos analysis, lack the stative subevent introduced by *v_{BE}*, e.g., (56). This restriction

further implies that any other environment in which stylistic *LE* occurs must involve an underlying inchoative representation. I return to this point later in section 5.

Throughout this section, I have argued that stylistic *LE* in Chilean Spanish involves an instance of multiple exponence: the applicative head is simultaneously realized as a dative clitic pronoun (*me* or *te*) and as the invariable form *LE*. Accordingly, *LE* could be described as an applicative marker that signals the presence of a neighboring dative (non-core) argument. The following section shows that this morphological split has broader consequences for the morphosyntax of anticausative constructions, particularly with respect to the expression and distribution of anticausative markers.

4.3 An alternative way to mark anticausativity

There remains to offer an analysis of sentences with stylistic *LE* that do not include the anticausative marker *SE*, e.g., (57b). This amounts to providing an account for the optionality of this element in pairs such as (57b) and (57c). That is, the proposal must explain both the acceptability of anticausative constructions without *SE*, and the semantic equivalence between sentences that include the marker and those that do not.

The analysis I advance here builds on the idea that anticausative markers have the role of overtly signaling the absence of an external argument in the underlying syntactic representation (Schäfer 2008, Alexiadou et al. 2015). I contend, however, that this requirement is ultimately morphological in nature and must be satisfied in the surface representation of the sentence. Particularly, while this condition is canonically met through syntactic means, e.g., by introducing an anticausative marker in a certain syntactic slot, I argue that it can also be satisfied by alternative mechanisms applying at PF.

The syntactic dimension of this system has been already depicted in section 4.1. As discussed, Schäfer (2008) and others propose that marked anticausative sentences contain a non-thematic version of Voice⁰ that neither introduces arguments nor contributes to event semantics. Although this instance of Voice⁰ is semantically inert, it carries a [D] feature requiring its specifier position to be filled with a reflexive pronoun (at least in languages such as Spanish or German). This system ensures that the semantically vacuous VoiceP projection receives some sort of formal marking at the surface level: the presence of the reflexive flags the underlying syntactic structure as anticausative.

Following the spirit of the strong minimalist thesis (Chomsky 2001, 2004), I contend that the presence of a [D] feature on non-thematic Voice⁰ is meant to satisfy a PF requirement. At the general level, the requirement is that verbs pertaining to a certain class of anticausatives must be overtly marked; as discussed by Alexiadou et al. (2015), the precise characterization of this class remains unclear, but seems to correlate with the relative non-spontaneity of the event expressed by these verbs or with the proportion of its causative versus anticausative uses. Different languages encode this condition in different ways. For the case of Spanish, I propose that the relevant PF requirement can be formulated as in (63).

- (63) The non-thematic VoiceP projection must be overtly marked on the verb by a reflexive clitic.

Being a PF condition, (63) can in principle be met through morphological mechanisms that apply post-syntactically. This is precisely what happens in contexts involving stylistic applicatives: their multiple exponence pattern provides an extra clitic that allows to fulfill (63). As discussed, the Fission operation in (59) produces two exponents from splitting the features of an applicative head Appl⁰. If Appl⁰ is 1SG, Fission produces the sequence of clitics *me le*; if Appl⁰ is 2SG, the result is the sequence *te le*. As can be seen in (64), both clitics that surface next to *LE* are syncretic with reflexives in Spanish. Since, syncretic elements are indistinguishable for PF purposes, they can satisfy the overt-marking requirement in (63) with no need for an anticausative marker in the narrow syntax.¹⁵

¹⁵In a sense, this analysis posits that multiple exponence may act as a repair strategy that fixes a syntactic issue. This trait makes the proposal similar to that in Pujalte & Saab (2012). They argue that the anticausative marker *SE* is inserted postsyntactically as a morphological repair mechanism rather than as a syntactic process. This operation is triggered by an unchecked [D] feature on the head that introduces the external argument. Since, according to their assumptions, all structure-building features must be discharged at PF, the clitic *SE* is inserted to “repair” the problem.

The main difference between the two analyses is that, in the present proposal, the anticausative marker is inserted in narrow syntax, whereas its absence can be “repaired” by an optional mechanism that is not necessarily triggered for this purpose. For Pujalte & Saab, by contrast, all anticausative markers are inserted postsyntactically

(64) Syncretisms in the American Spanish clitic system

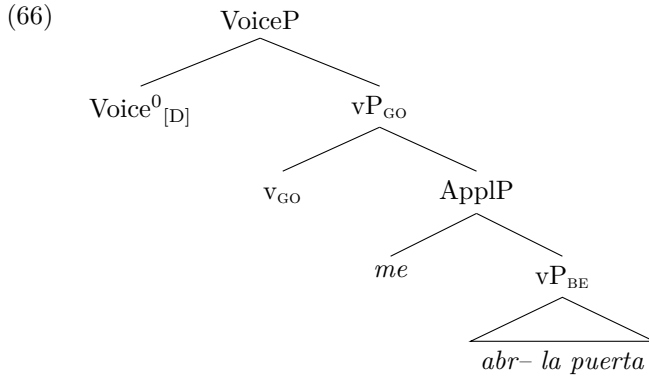
	ACCUSATIVE	DATIVE	REFLEXIVE
1SG	<i>me</i>	<i>me</i>	<i>me</i>
2SG	<i>te</i>	<i>te</i>	<i>te</i>
3SG	<i>los/las</i>	<i>le/se</i>	<i>se</i>
1PL	<i>nos</i>	<i>nos</i>	<i>nos</i>
2/3PL	<i>los/las</i>	<i>les/se</i>	<i>se</i>

A need to satisfy (63) in this way, however, only arises when no reflexive pronoun is merged in the specifier of non-thematic Voice⁰; this scenario may obtain if no reflexive element is included in the Numeration (Chomsky 1995). In such cases, the subcategorization [D] feature on the Voice head remains unchecked. Following Preminger (2014), Longenbaugh (2019) and Newman (2024), I adopt the view that unchecked features do not immediately produce ungrammaticality: the interfaces will still attempt to interpret and pronounce the resulting structure, and they will filter it out if they cannot process it. This idea is captured in (65).

(65) FEATURE FAILURE (Newman 2024: 15)

If no element is present that may check a Merge feature [F], [F] may unproblematically fail without crashing the derivation.

These assumptions make it possible to account for stylistic applicative patterns of the form $CL_{dat} + LE$ that lack the anticausative marker *SE*. Consider the example in (57b). Since this is an anticausative sentence without an anticausative marker, it must be the case that the specifier position of VoiceP remains empty, and consequently that the [D] feature on non-thematic Voice⁰ remains unchecked. The corresponding syntactic structure is shown in (66).



Given the principle in (65), this representation is sent to the interfaces, where it will be filtered out if it violates interface-specific constraints. On the LF side, no problem should arise: since the non-thematic VoiceP projection is semantically empty, no difference in meaning is expected relative to “complete” structures such as (58), which do contain an element in Spec,VoiceP; the representation should therefore be interpretable at the semantic level. At the PF side, however, a violation of the condition in (63) is predicted to occur in most Spanish varieties, since narrow syntax provides no reflexive element to overtly signal that the underlying structure is anticausative.

This issue is prevented with stylistic applicative constructions in Chilean Spanish. As discussed, the applicative head *me* in (66) becomes the sequence *me le* due to the instance of Fission depicted in (61). While the clitic *LE* in the sequence serves as the phonological realization for Appl⁰, the clitic *me* is reanalyzed as a reflexive due to syncretism. Since PF takes *me* to be a reflexive, it satisfies the overt-marking condition in (63), and the resulting sentence is acceptable.

We may think of this process as filling the available slots in a template. The surface representation of the syntactic structure in (66) should contain at least two clitics: (i) one corresponding to the VoiceP projection, which marks the predicate as anticausative and satisfies (63); and (ii) another that spells out the applicative head. In principle, (66) provides no reflexive element to serve as the phonological

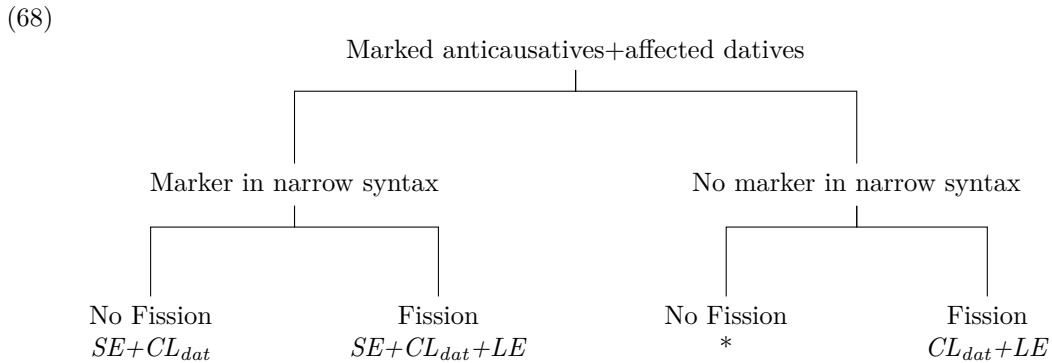
and are the result of a repair operation.

realization of VoiceP, so the derivation should crash at PF, e.g., (67a). However, if Fission supplies an additional exponent that can be interpreted as the externalization of VoiceP, then the resulting phonological representation will satisfy (63) and converge at PF, e.g., (67b).¹⁶

- (67) a. $\underbrace{\text{me}}_{\text{VoiceP}} \quad \underbrace{\text{me}}_{\text{Appl}^0}$ *violates (63)*
b. $\underbrace{\text{me}}_{\text{VoiceP}} \quad \underbrace{\text{le}}_{\text{Appl}^0}$ *satisfies (63)*

The analysis developed in this and the previous subsection allows us to propose a typology of alternative realizations for sentences that combine marked anticausatives with affected datives in Chilean Spanish. On one side of the typology are realizations in which the anticausative marker is introduced in Spec, VoiceP. Within this group, two configurations arise. If the applicative head does not undergo Fission, the structure surfaces as the standard Spanish pattern, with a clitic cluster of the form *SE+CL_{dat}*, e.g., (57a). If the applicative head does undergo Fission, stylistic *LE* appears and produces a cluster of the form *SE+CL_{dat}+LE*, e.g., (57c).

On the other side, there are realizations in which no anticausative marker is introduced during the syntactic derivation. In such cases, the only convergent option is to apply Fission on Appl⁰, so that the resulting pattern of multiple exponence satisfies the condition in (63) and, in a sense, rescues the derivation. This produces a clitic cluster of the form *CL_{dat}+LE*, e.g., (57b). The scheme in (68) summarizes the classification.



5 Extending the analysis to (other) unaccusative contexts

As discussed in section 2, stylistic applicatives in Chilean Spanish may surface with (i) *SE*-marked anticausative predicates, (ii) unaccusative predicates that may combine with *SE*, and (iii) type III psychological predicates formed with *SE*. The analysis presented in the previous section was devoted to account for the phenomenon in anticausative contexts. In this section, I will extend the proposal to the latter two scenarios.

Let's consider first the case of unaccusative verbs marked with *SE*. The relevant examples were presented in (13) and (14), and are repeated for convenience in (69) and (70).

¹⁶This account assumes as a background principle that PF enforces the pronunciation of syntactic terminals in order to produce a faithful surface representation of the sentence. This idea has been articulated by various authors under different labels, e.g., Kurisu's (2001) *Realize Morpheme* or Fábregas's (2007) *Exhaustive Lexicalization Principle*. Without this assumption, the analysis of the absence of *SE* in (67) would overgenerate.

To illustrate, consider again the structure in (66). Even if no Fission applied to provide an additional exponent, the applicative head *me* could in principle be reanalyzed as syncretic with a 1SG reflexive clitic, thus satisfying the condition in (63). However, such a reanalysis would leave Appl⁰ without an overt exponent, e.g., (i). This option is ruled out because the grammar requires Appl⁰ (and all non-null terminals) to be pronounced.

- (i) $\underbrace{\text{me}}_{\text{VoiceP}} \quad \underbrace{\quad}_{\text{Appl}^0}$ *unfaithful output*

- (69) a. Se me cayeron las llaves.
 SE 1SG.DAT fell.3PL the keys
 ‘The keys fell for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally dropped the keys.’
 b. Me le cayeron las llaves.
 1SG.DAT LE fell.3PL the keys
 c. Se me le cayeron las llaves.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE fell.3PL the keys
- (70) a. Se me murió la planta.
 SE 1SG.DAT died.3SG the plant
 ‘The plant died for/on/to me.’
 ‘I unintentionally killed the plant.’
 b. Me le murió la planta.
 1SG.DAT LE died.3SG the plant
 c. Se me le murió la planta.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE died.3SG the plant

In principle, *SE* does not seem to alter the syntax or the semantics of these verbs. As can be seen in (71) and (72), both *caer* ‘fall’ and *morir* ‘die’ have an unaccusative syntax even without *SE*. Moreover, adding the reflexive seemingly preserves the interpretation of each example.¹⁷

- (71) a. Cayó una persona al río.
 fell.3SG a person to.the river
 ‘A person fell in the river.’
 b. Se cayó una persona al río.
 SE fell.3SG a person to.the river
- (72) a. Murió nuestra mascota.
 died.3SG our pet
 ‘Our pet died.’
 b. Se murió nuestra mascota.
 SE died.3SG our pet

However, the presence/absence of *SE* in these sentences does determine some key differences. According to Cuervo (2014, 2015), these differences follow from the examples without *SE* in (71a) and (72a) being simple unaccusative verbs, while the *SE*-marked variants in (71b) and (72b) involve inchoative predicates. In Cuervo’s system, the underlying structure of the former includes a single head v_{GO} , which introduces a dynamic event of change, e.g., (73a); in the case of the latter, the representation contains two event introducers, v_{GO} and v_{BE} , which compose a bi-eventive structure, e.g., (73b).



Cuervo (2014) points several differences between these predicates supporting an analysis on these lines; I refer to her work for a more detailed discussion. One telling contrast is that only unaccusatives can combine with bare nouns. As shown in (74) and (75), the inchoative *SE*-marked variants of these verbs do not accept these nominals.

¹⁷As noticed by Cuervo (2015: 408), the fact that both variants of these verbs are unaccusative argues against analyses of anticausative *SE* as a reflexivization operator (Chierchia 2004, Koontz-Garboden 2009); see 3.2 above.

- (74) a. Caen piedras.
 fall.3PL stones
 ‘Stones are falling.’
 b. *Se caen piedras.
 SE fall.3PL stones
- (75) a. En esa guerra murieron inocentes.
 in that war died.3PL innocents
 ‘In that war innocent people died.’
 b. ?? En esa guerra se murieron inocentes.
 in that war SE died.3PL innocents

The same effect is attested with other inchoative predicates, e.g., *SE*-marked anticausatives.

- (76) *Se derretieron mantecas.
 SE melted.3PL butters
 ‘Butters melted.’

This is captured by the structures in (73). The DP argument in the inchoative structure in (73b) is the “subject” of the stative vP, i.e., it occupies the Spec,vP_{be} position. Since bare nouns cannot be subjects in Spanish (Suñer 1982), they cannot merge into this position. In contrast, the DP argument in the unaccusative structure in (73a) is an object, i.e., the complement of V. Therefore, the former restriction does not apply in this case.¹⁸

The analysis I propose for these constructions combines Cuervo’s structures in (73) and aspects of Saab’s (2020) take on *SE*-marked unaccusative verbs. Saab deals with *SE* in examples such as (71b) and (72b) in the same way as he does with anticausative *SE*, i.e., he treats them as elements that are inserted in Spec,VoiceP to fulfill an expletive-like role. He contends that Voice⁰ is semantically vacuous in unaccusatives with and without *SE*, but only in the *SE*-marked variants it carries a subcategorization

¹⁸In principle, a further prediction stemming from the structures in (73) is that the unaccusative variants without *SE* cannot host affected datives. As discussed in 4.1, these non-core arguments occupy a position between the vP_{GO} and vP_{BE} projections, which only appear together in the inchoative structure in (73b). As the example in (i) shows, this prediction is borne out, at least for certain verbs.

- (i) *Le murió la planta.
 dat.3SG died.3SG the plant
 ‘The plant died for/on/to him.’

In contrast, it is perfectly grammatical to introduce an affected dative in an inchoative structure with *SE*.

- (ii) Se le murió la planta.
 SE dat.3SG died.3SG the plant
 ‘The plant died for/on/to him.’
 ‘He/she unintentionally killed the plant.’

An anonymous reviewer points out that this prediction does not seem to hold, as certain unaccusative predicates without *SE* do allow dative arguments with what appears to be an affected reading, e.g., (iii).

- (iii) A Juan le cayeron varias hojas.
 DAT Juan 3SG.DAT fell.3PL several leaves
 ‘Several leaves fell onto Juan.’

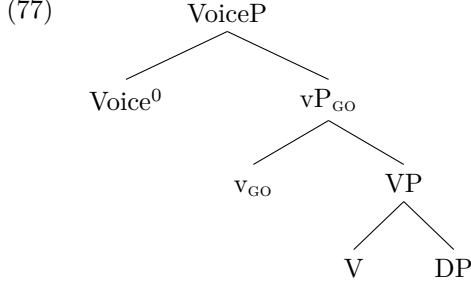
To my ears, however, this example does not convey that Juan was affected by the falling of the leaves, but rather that the leaves fell over him. This may suggest that the underlying syntactic representation for (iii) differs from that assumed for (i). Supporting this, note that when *SE* is incorporated into (iii), as in (iv), the interpretation shifts: the reading that the leaves fell onto Juan is not available anymore.

- (iv) A Juan se le cayeron varias hojas.
 DAT Juan 3SG.DAT fell.3PL several leaves
 ‘The leaves fell for/on/to Juan.’
 ‘Juan unintentionally dropped several leaves.’

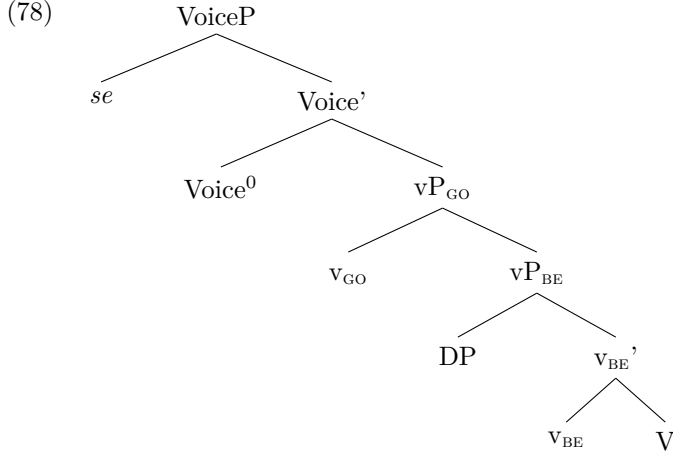
In sum, further research is needed to determine whether the prediction holds in full.

feature requiring insertion of the reflexive. Thus, according to him, the morphological distinction in pairs such as (71) and (72) reduces to the presence/absence of a formal feature in Voice^0 .

Adopting Saab's idea, I take that the instance of Voice^0 that does not require *SE* combines with the unaccusative structure in (73a). This produces a representation like (77), which is the underlying structure proposed for the predicates in (71a) and (72a).



On the other hand, the instance of Voice^0 requiring insertion of the reflexive selects the inchoative structure in (73b). This results in the representation in (78), which corresponds to the predicates in (71b) and (72b).



From this point on, the analysis for the stylistic *LE* examples in (69) and (70) follows the lines depicted throughout section 4. That is, the base sentences in (69a) and (70a) result from the scheme in (79), which is basically the structure in (78) with an applicative projection between vP_{GO} and vP_{BE} . Notice that (79) is entirely analogous to the representation provided in (58).

$$(79) \quad [\text{VoiceP } se \text{ } [\text{Voice}' \text{ } \text{Voice}^0 \text{ } [vP_{GO} \text{ } v_{GO} \text{ } [\text{ApplP } me \text{ } [vP_{BE} \text{ } DP \text{ } [v_{BE}' \text{ } vP_{BE} \text{ } V \text{ }]]]]]]]$$

As discussed in section 4, sentences exhibiting stylistic applicatives in clitic clusters of the form *SE+CL_{dat}+LE* involve (i) merging the anticausative marker *SE* in Spec, VoiceP, and (ii) applying the Fission operation in (60) to Appl⁰. This analysis accounts for the examples in (69c) and (70c): while their underlying syntactic representation corresponds to (79), they additionally display multiple exponence of Appl⁰ as a result of Fission.

By contrast, the stylistic *LE* patterns of the form *CL_{dat}+LE* in (69b) and (70b), which lack the anticausative marker *SE*, involve a syntactic representation in which this element is not merged in Spec, VoiceP. The resulting structure, shown in (80), is identical to that in (66). Since no anticausative marker is provided by narrow syntax, the overt-marking condition in (63) can only be satisfied through the post-syntactic application of Fission, as discussed above in section 4.3.

$$(80) \quad [\text{VoiceP } \text{Voice}^0 \text{ } [vP_{GO} \text{ } v_{GO} \text{ } [\text{ApplP } me \text{ } [vP_{BE} \text{ } DP \text{ } [v_{BE}' \text{ } vP_{BE} \text{ } V \text{ }]]]]]]$$

As seen, instances of stylistic *LE* with *SE*-marked unaccusative predicates receive basically the same analysis as their counterparts with *SE*-marked anticausatives. Evidence supporting a common analysis comes from the fact that dative arguments in both types of structure may receive an unintentional causer interpretation.

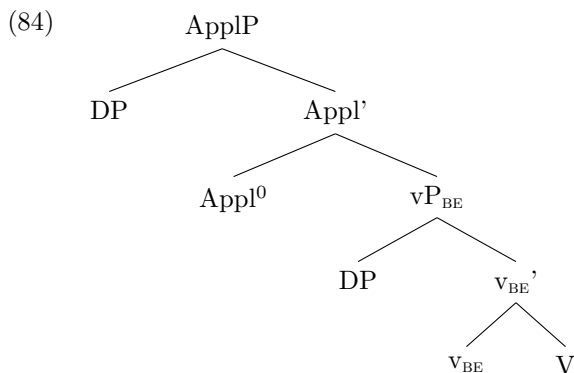
Now, let's consider the behavior of psych-verbs licensing stylistic *LE* and determine whether the same line of analysis applied so far can be extended to them. For convenience, the relevant examples are repeated in (81) and (82).

- (81) a. Se me olvidó eso.
SE 1SG,DAT forgot.3SG that
'I forgot that.'
b. Me le olvidó eso.
1SG.DAT LE forgot.3SG that
c. Se me le olvidó eso.
SE 1SG.DAT LE forgot.3SG that
- (82) a. Se me ocurrió una idea.
SE 1SG.DAT occurred.3SG a idea
'An idea occurred to me.'
b. Me le ocurrió una idea.
1SG.DAT LE occurred.3SG a idea
c. Se me le ocurrió una idea.
SE 1SG.DAT LE occurred.3SG a idea

As previously mentioned, these sentences involve *SE*-marked predicates that behave at the surface level like type III psych-verbs. That is, they form unaccusative configurations in which the dative argument is interpreted as an experiencer, much in the same way as verbs like *gustar* 'like' in (83c).

- (83) a. A Cosmo se le olvidaron los libros.
DAT Cosmo SE 3SG.DAT forgot.3PL the peaches
'Cosmo liked the peaches.'
b. A Cosmo se le ocurrió la respuesta.
DAT Cosmo SE 3SG.DAT occurred.3PL the answer
'The answer occurred to Cosmo.'
c. A Cosmo le gustaron los duraznos.
DAT Cosmo 3SG.DAT liked.3PL the peaches
'Cosmo liked the peaches.'

Cuervo's (2003) analysis for psych predicates of the *gustar* type is sketched in (84). As can be seen, she proposes a structure in which a high applicative attaches to a stative vP_{BE} projection; the experiencer DP is introduced as the specifier of ApplP.



This analysis captures the observation that dative experiencer psych-verbs in Spanish are systematically stative (Marín & McNally 2011, Fábregas & Marín 2020). For instance, they reject speed adverbials such as *rápido* ‘quickly’, e.g., (85).

- (85) A Juan le gusta Sandra (*rápido).
 DAT Juan 3SG.DAT likes.3SG Sandra quickly
 ‘Juan (quickly) likes Sandra.’

The stativity of psych verbs with dative experiencers contrasts sharply with the dinamicity displayed by *SE*-marked psych-verbs such as *olvidarse* ‘forget’ or *acordarse* ‘remember’. As can be seen in (86), these verbs can combine with speed adverbials.

- (86) a. Juan se olvida de todo (rápido).
 Juan SE forgets of all quickly
 ‘Juan (quickly) forgets everything.’

A further property showing that *gustar*-like predicates are stative while *acordarse*-like ones are dynamic is that only the latter trigger episodic or habitual interpretations when in present tense. For instance, (86) means that Juan habitually has episodes of forgetting everything. Such a reading is impossible to obtain in (85), since in this case there is a unique and permanent event of liking Sandra.

This distinction is important because the psych predicates licensing stylistic *LE* in (81) and (82) involve both dative experiencers and *SE*-marking. Fábregas & Marín (2020) observe that, in cases like these, the resulting predicates are dynamic; they conjecture that the dynamic interpretation associated to structures with *SE* overrides the stative contribution of the dative experiencer. As shown in (87) and (88), their observations are correct for the patterns under discussion here: all relevant examples accept modification by speed adverbs and trigger habitual interpretations in the present tense.

- (87) a. Se me olvida rápido el número.
 SE 1SG.DAT forget.3SG quickly the number
 ‘I (habitually) forget the number quickly.’
 b. Me le olvida rápido el número.
 1SG.DAT LE forget.3SG quickly the number
 c. Se me le olvida rápido el número.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE forget.3SG quickly the number
- (88) a. Se me ocurre rápido la solución.
 SE 1SG.DAT occurs.3SG quickly the solution
 ‘The solution (habitually) occurs to me quickly.’
 b. Me le ocurre rápido la solución.
 1SG.DAT LE occurs.3SG quickly the solution
 c. Se me le ocurre rápido la idea.
 SE 1SG.DAT LE occurs.3SG quickly the solution

Thus, these patterns combine aspects of the predicates in (85) and (86): on one hand, they have the basic syntax of type III psych-verbs like *gustar* ‘like’; on the other, they encode dynamic rather than stative events. To account for this mixture, I begin by assuming that the underlying structures of the base cases in (81a) and (82a) recruit the scheme that Cuervo (2003) postulates for type III psych predicates in (84). I contend that this configuration serves as the complement for a dynamic v_{GO} head; I take this to have the effect of giving a non-stative interpretation to an otherwise stative predicate. Finally, *SE* is inserted as the specifier of a non-thematic Voice projection selecting vP_{GO} as its complement. The resulting representation is sketched in (89).

- (89) [VoiceP *se* [Voice' Voice⁰ [vP_{GO} v_{GO} [AppIP *me* [vP_{BE} DP [v_{BE} ' vP_{BE} V]]]]]]]

Notice that (89) is parallel to the structure proposed for *SE*-marked anticausatives in (58) and identical to the analysis for *SE*-marked unaccusatives in (79). This amounts to stating that these psych predicates have an underlying inchoative representation. Cuervo (2020) suggests dealing with examples such as (83a) in these terms, as she contends that the experiencer interpretation of the DP in these sentences “could be the result of the psychological nature of the predicate in an inchoative structure, in which a dative argument would typically be read as an accidental causer” (Cuervo 2020: 32).¹⁹ Since (58) and (79) are, by assumption, structures able to trigger unintentional causer interpretations on dative arguments, the analysis depicted in (89) converges with Cuervo’s conjectures.

Once the analysis of the base scenarios has been developed, the treatment of patterns with stylistic *LE* proceeds according to the steps outlined in section 4. Specifically, the examples in (81c) and (82c) involve the structure in (89) combined with postsyntactic Fission, which produces a clitic cluster of the form *SE+CL_{dat}+LE*. By contrast, the examples in (81b) and (82b) are based on the structure in (90), which lacks the anticausative marker *SE*; therefore, Fission results in a clitic cluster of the form *CL_{dat}+LE*.

$$(90) \quad [\text{VoiceP} \text{ Voice}^0 [\text{vP}_{\text{GO}} \text{ v}_{\text{GO}} [\text{ApplP} \text{ me} [\text{vP}_{\text{BE}} \text{ DP} [\text{v}_{\text{BE}}' \text{ vP}_{\text{BE}} \text{ V}]]]]]]$$

Summing up, the analysis of stylistic applicatives in anticausative contexts also holds for the remaining syntactic configurations licensing the pattern. In particular, by extending the proposal in section 4 to other types of predicates, a more fine-grained characterization of the distribution of stylistic applicatives emerges: the phenomenon arises with *SE*-marked inchoative predicates incorporating a (high) applicative head.

6 Concluding remarks

In this paper, I have argued that Spanish anticausative *SE* contributes no semantic content and functions instead as a purely formal marker that signals the presence of an underlying anticausative structure. The evidence comes from the phenomenon of stylistic applicatives, an understudied pattern in Chilean Spanish where the clitic form *LE* appears alongside dative clitics in marked anticausative contexts. Crucially, *SE* is optional in this construction, i.e., stylistic applicative patterns without *SE* remain anticausative and convey the same meaning as their *SE*-marked counterparts. This shows that *SE* is an element with no role in the semantics of the predicate.

I have proposed a morphosyntactic account of stylistic applicatives that captures their most salient properties. The analysis treats the pattern as a case of multiple exponence, in which an applicative head surfaces as a sequence of clitics consisting on (i) a pronoun that can be either *me* or *te* and (ii) an invariable element *LE*. This process produces clitic clusters of the form *SE+CL_{dat}+LE* or *CL_{dat}+LE*, depending on whether *SE* is included or not.

The optionality of *SE* in these contexts follows from the morphological composition of the clitic cluster. I have proposed that the requirement to mark anticausative predicates holds at PF and, in Spanish, specifies that the verb must be associated with a reflexive clitic. Since the clitics *me* and *te* that obtain through Fission are syncretic with reflexive morphology, they can fulfill this formal condition. As a result, the presence of such a syncretic element in stylistic applicative constructions can satisfy the reflexive marking requirement, thereby allowing *SE* to be absent from the syntactic representation.

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¹⁹Notice, however, that Cuervo argues that affected datives and unintentional causers involve different syntactic structures, an assumption from which I depart here. See 4.1 above for discussion.

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